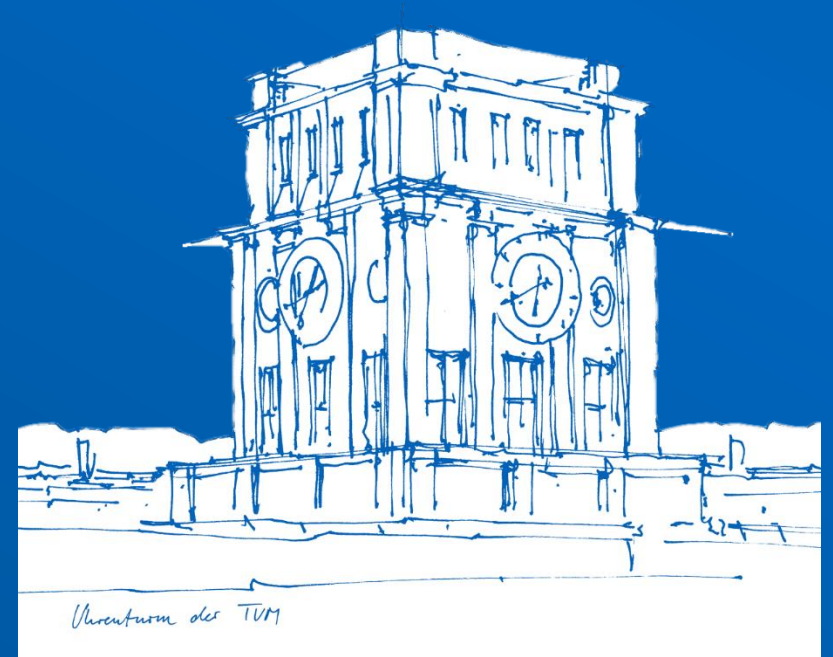


SMART goals – and beyond

Vogele Alexander
June 08, 2025



Setting goals is easy, reaching them isn't.

December:



Highly motivated, you set your goals for the new year.

January:



You train hard – surrounded by others chasing their goals.

February:



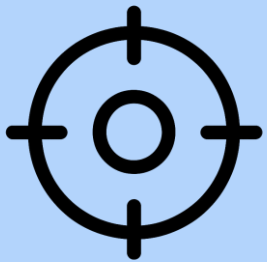
Motivation already fades. Many let go of their goals.



**How do we really manage to
achieve our goals?**

USE SMART to achieve your goals

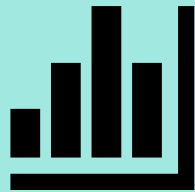
S



Specific

Set **specific** and **well-defined** goals

M



Measurable

Define goals in **measurable** and **trackable** terms

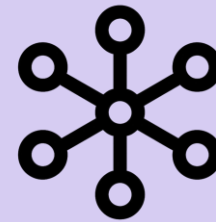
A



Attainable

Set goals that are **attainable** and **achievable**

R



Realistic

Make sure goals **support** your overall **strategy**

T



Time-bound

Give your goals a **deadline** and clear **timeframe**



**What did I expect – and
what surprised me during
my research?**

SMART goals are not as clear as i thought..



Specific

**Simple
Sensible
Significant
Strategic**



Measurable

**Meaningful
Motivating**



Attainable

**Acceptable
Achievable
Action-oriented
Assignable**



Realistic

**Relevant
Reviewable
Rewarding
Relative
Reasonable**



Time-bound

**Trackable
Tangible
Time-frame
Time-specific
Truthful**

SMART goals are getting criticism..



Specific

Simple
Specific
Sensible
Significant



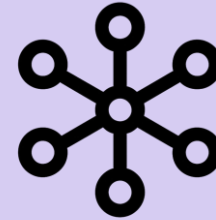
Measurable

Meaningful
Motivating



Attainable

Acceptable
Achievable
Action-oriented



Realistic

Relevant
Reviewable
Rewarding
Relative
Reasonable



Time-bound

Trackable
Tangible
Time-frame
Time-specific
Truthful

Under strong pressure

Beyond SMART: new models, but no leader

Model		Definition	Advantages
FAST	>	Frequently discussed, Ambitious, Specific, Transparent	⊕ Pushes beyond comfort zone ⊕ Foster culture of continuous improvement ⊕ Better teamwork by alignment and transparency
HARD	>	Heartfelt, Animated, Required & Difficult	⊕ Pushes beyond comfort zone ⊕ Increases emotional engagement & motivation ⊕ Creates strong commitment
OKR	>	Objectives & Key Results	⊕ Pushes beyond comfort zone ⊕ Enables a more agile and adaptive goal setting ⊕ Better teamwork by alignment and transparency

One Slide of a book or scientific article you found in particular useful

Goal setting theory of Locke/Latham

Goals should be “challenging”.

Building a Practically Useful Theory of Goal Setting and Task Motivation

A 35-Year Odyssey

Edwin A. Locke University of Maryland
Gary P. Latham University of Toronto



Edwin A. Locke



Gary P. Latham

Despite the above results, there can be no doubt that the subconscious is a storehouse of knowledge and values beyond that which is in focal awareness at any given time (Murphy, 2001). People can take action without being fully aware of what is motivating them or what stored knowledge is affecting their choices. The lack of focus on the subconscious is a limitation of goal-setting theory. In the 19th century, the Würzburg school (Ach, Warr, Külpe, and others)—a school that influenced Lewis—showed that assigned goals (they used the term *tasks*) could affect action at a later time without people being aware of it. Research is now needed on the effect of the subconscious on goals and on the ways in which goals arouse and effect subconscious knowledge. As an initial step in this direction, Wegge and Döbbel (2000) found that hard goals automatically enhanced the speed of information processing.

Goal-setting theory states that, irrespective of the subconscious, conscious motivation affects performance and job satisfaction. This is especially true for people who choose to be purposeful and proactive (Biswaswanger, 1991). As Bandura (1997) noted, people have the power to actively control their lives through purposeful thought; this includes the power to program and reprogram their subconscious, to choose their own goals, to pull out from the subconscious what is relevant to their purpose and to ignore what is not, and to guide their actions based on what they want to accomplish.

Conclusion

The essential elements of goal-setting theory, along with the high-performance cycle model, are summarized in Figure 4. Goal-setting theory is fully consistent with social-cognitive theory in that both acknowledge the importance of conscious goals and self-efficacy. The two theories differ in emphasis and scope. The focus of goal-setting theory is on the core properties of an effective goal. These properties are as follows: specificity and difficulty

level; goal effects at the individual, group, and organization levels; the proper use of learning versus performance goals; mediators of goal effects; the moderators of goal effects; the role of goals as mediators of other incentives; and the effect of goal source (e.g., assigned vs. self-set vs. participatively set).

Goal-setting theory is not limited to but focuses primarily on motivation in work settings. Social-cognitive theory and the research that underlies it are primarily focused on self-efficacy, its measurement, its causes, and its consequences at the individual, group, and societal levels in numerous domains of functioning. Social-cognitive theory also discusses the effects of and processes underlying modeling, cognitive development, moral judgment, language development, and physiological arousal. Despite these differences, the two theories agree about what is considered important in performance motivation. A detailed discussion of the relationship of goal theory to other work motivation theories is presented in Locke (1997).

The effects of goal setting are very reliable. Failures to replicate them are usually due to errors, such as not matching the goal to the performance measure, not providing feedback, not getting goal commitment, not measuring the person's personal (self-set) goals, not conveying task knowledge, setting a performance goal when a specific high-learning goal is required, not setting proximal goals when the environment is characterized by uncertainty, or not including a sufficient range of goal difficulty levels (see

Locke & Latham, 1990, chapter 7)

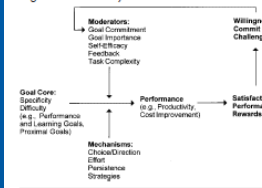
A key issue involved in theory building is that of generalization. With goal-setting theory, specific difficult goals have been shown to increase performance on well over 100 different tasks involving more than 40,000 participants in at least eight countries working in laboratory, simulation, and field settings. The dependent variables have included quantity, quality, time spent, costs, job behavior measures, and more. The time spans have ranged from 1 minute to 25 years. The effects are applicable not only to the individual but to groups (O'Leary-Kelly, Martocchio, & Frink, 1994), organizational units (Rogers & Hunter, 1991), and entire organizations (Baum, Locke, & Smith, 2001). The effects have been found using experimental, quasi-experimental, and correlational designs. Effects have been obtained whether the goals are assigned, self-set, or set participatively. In short, goal-setting theory is among the most valid and practical theories of employee motivation in organizational psychology (C. Lee & Earley, 1992; Minner, 1994; Pinder, 1998). Isn't it time that psychologists took consciousness, including conscious motivation, seriously (Locke, 1995)?

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Figure 4
Essential Elements of Goal-Setting Theory and the High-Performance Cycle



Research question for master thesis

1. Are SMART goals an effective management tool for performance-based compensation in management consulting?
2. Do challenging team-level goals, compared to attainable ones, lead to greater progress and performance in the strategy departments of ProSieben and BASF over the past three years?
3. To what extent do the ESG goals published in the 2025 sustainability reports of DAX-40 companies meet the SMART criteria (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound)?

3. Data Fields (per goal):

Company	ESG Dimension (E/S/G)	Goal (verbatim)	Specific	Measurable	Achievable	Relevant	Time-bound	SMART Score (0-5)
BASF	Environmental	"Reduce CO ₂ emissions by 25% by 2030"	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	5
Allianz	Social	"Increase women in leadership roles"	✗	✓	✓	✓	✗	3
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Master thesis should not be open ended! You should not start with how-> will be too broad! Try to be very specific. And think about dataset. Dataset and compare it against.

She asks bei Masterthesis: What Dataset would you use

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